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THE KING'S LODGE

Discovering the Psalms

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Part 7 Continued

Imprecatory Psalms

Imprecatory Psalms

- Examples: Psalms 35, 58, 59, 69, 83, 94, 109, 137

Psalm 58:3-8

3 The wicked go astray from the womb;
they err from their birth, speaking lies.
4 They have venom like the venom of a serpent,
like the deaf adder that stops its ear,
5 so that it does not hear the voice of charmers
or of the cunning enchanter.
6 O God, break the teeth in their mouths;
tear out the fangs of the young lions, O Lord!
7 Let them vanish like water that runs away;
like grass let them be trodden down and wither.
8 Let them be like the snail that dissolves into slime;
like the untimely birth that never sees the sun.

Psalm 58:3-8

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they err from their birth, speaking lies.
[4]They have venom like the venom of a serpent,
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like the untimely birth that never sees the sun.

Psalm 83:9-15

9 Do to them as you did to Midian,
as to Sisera and Jabin at the river Kishon,
10 who were destroyed at En- dor,
who became dung for the ground.
11 Make their nobles like Oreb and Zeeb,
all their princes like Zebah and Zalmunna,
12 who said, “Let us take possession for ourselves
of the pastures of God.”
13 O my God, make them like whirling dust,
like chaff before the wind.
14 As fire consumes the forest,
as the flame sets the mountains ablaze,
15 so may you pursue them with your tempest
and terrify them with your hurricane

Psalm 83:9-15

Judges 4

Judges 7 and 8

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Psalm 137:7-9

7 Remember, O Lord, against the Edomites
the day of Jerusalem,
how they said, “Lay it bare, lay it bare, down to its
foundations!”
8 O daughter of Babylon, doomed to be destroyed,
blessed shall he be who repays you
with what you have done to us!
9 Blessed shall he be who takes your little ones
and dashes them against the rock

Considerations of such Psalms

- Remember:
- These Psalms are the response of people in very difficult and dangerous situations

Considerations of such Psalms

- Remember:
- They were experiencing injustice, oppression, danger, loss, bereavement and enemies seeking to kill them

Psalm 137 as an Example:

Psalm 137:7-9

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the day of Jerusalem,
how they said, “Lay it bare, lay it bare, down to its foundations!”
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Psalms 137 Setting:

- Nebuchadnezzar had completely destroyed Jerusalem and Judea 586BC

Psalms 137 Setting:

- It was a time of unimaginable violence, cruelty and loss

Psalms 137 Setting:

- The nation had been destroyed
- Thousands had lost their lives

Psalms 137 Setting:

- The nation of Edom has been involved in ransacking, looting and perpetuating the violence

Psalms 137 Setting:

- Most of those who had not been killed where marched as refugees into captivity

Imprecations are primarily:

- Calls for judicial penalties to be applied to the guilty, that is praying for justice to be done

Imprecations are primarily:

- Asking for punishments that correspond to the crime
- This was how punishment worked in the ancient world

Imprecations are primarily:

- Asking God to fulfill prophetic oracles already issued
- See Obadiah regarding Edom

Imprecations are primarily:

- Asking God to fulfill prophetic oracles already issued
- See Isaiah 13, especially v. 16 regarding Babylon:

Isaiah 13:15-16

15…Whoever is found will be thrust through,

and whoever is caught will fall by the sword.

16 Their infants will be dashed to pieces

before their eyes;

their houses will be plundered, and their wives ravished…

How do We Respond to Injustice etc.?

- Seek personal revenge
- OR
- Suppress or deny the feelings of hurt and anger
- OR
- Take those feelings to God

These Psalms Teach Us to:

- Express honestly the pain, anger, injustice, fear, loss and desire for retribution in prayer to God
- This surely is the best way to handle such awful situations

These Psalms Teach Us to:

- Let God be the Judge!
- Through such prayers we are releasing judgement to him
- cf Romans 12:19